In memory of

Cyril Roy Phillips

SX8216

Craftsman, Second Australian Imperial Force, 1940–1944



From his enlistment photograph, 1940 (digitally colourised).

✦ ✦ ✦

Egypt · Libya · Palestine · Syria · Ceylon · New Guinea

A record of his war service, compiled for his family · 2026

FOREWORD

A blacksmith from the Mallee

Cyril Roy Phillips was born at Port Broughton, South Australia, on 9 August 1917. When he volunteered for the Second AIF in the winter of 1940 he was 22, single, a Methodist, and a working blacksmith at Lowaldie in the Murray Mallee, where his mother, Mildred Maud Phillips, lived. The army described him as having brown hair and blue eyes.

He was enlisted at Adelaide on 6 July 1940 as Private SX8216. Because he was a skilled tradesman, the army graded him a Group I Blacksmith and posted him to the 2/2nd Army Field Workshops, a unit that recovered and repaired the army's vehicles, tanks and guns. He served with that unit and its successors for more than four years: in the Western Desert of Egypt and Libya, in Palestine, Transjordan and Lebanon, in Ceylon, and for fourteen months in New Guinea. Illness (high blood pressure) brought him home in February 1944. He married Irene May on 25 March 1944, and he was discharged at Wayville on 28 November 1944 after 1,607 days of service, 1,129 of them overseas.

Cyril died on 7 January 1977, aged 59, and was buried at Dudley Park Cemetery, Adelaide, on 11 January 1977. Irene, then living at Mile End, survived him.

This booklet sets out what the surviving records say about where he went and what he did. His own service record is the backbone. It is filled out with his unit's war diaries, the unit history written by its commanding officer, Brigadier George Moran, and photographs from the Australian War Memorial. Where the records name Cyril, that is stated as fact. Where we can only follow his unit, or join the dots, this is shown clearly, along with the evidence for each conclusion.

At a glance

Born	9 Aug 1917, Port Broughton SA
Enlisted	6 Jul 1940, Adelaide (2nd AIF)
Trade	Blacksmith, Group I; re-graded Group I Fitter, 1944
Units	2/2 Army Field Workshops; 6 Aust Div Ordnance Workshop (16 Bde Section); 2/121 Aust Bde Workshops AEME; 7 Tech Maint Section
Overseas	Middle East 1940–42 · Ceylon 1942 · New Guinea Dec 1942–Feb 1944
Married	Irene May, 25 Mar 1944
Discharged	28 Nov 1944, Wayville; medically unfit
Medals	1939–45 Star, Africa Star, Pacific Star, Defence Medal, War Medal 1939–45, Australia Service Medal 1939–45
Died	7 Jan 1977, aged 59; buried Dudley Park

How to read this booklet

From his own record
Facts taken from Cyril's own service record (NAA B883, SX8216) or from unit documents that name him.

What his unit was doing
From the unit war diaries and history. They show where his unit or section was, but they do not name him.

The evidence suggests — confidence
A reasoned conclusion where the dates and records line up. Each one has a **Based on** note giving the records and reasoning, and a rough confidence level.

THE PHOTOGRAPH

Private Phillips, 1940



Cyril Roy Phillips, SX8216, at enlistment in Adelaide, mid-1940. *Digitally coloured; original black-and-white photograph from his attestation papers, NAA: B883, SX8216, p. 4 (item 6411180). His service record gives his hair as brown and his eyes as blue, and the colours were checked against that. Skin and uniform tones are an interpretation.*



The original. *The front and profile photographs as they appear on his attestation form (NAA: B883, SX8216, p. 4). The height scale on the right reads in feet and inches.*

> FROM HIS OWN RECORD
>
> Hair: brown. Eyes: blue. Distinguishing marks: a small cyst behind and below the left ear, two scars on both knees, and a birthmark on the left shoulder.
>
> Service and Casualty Form, NAA: B883, SX8216, p. 5.

No other photograph of Cyril was found in the Australian War Memorial online collection, which was searched by name and service number for this booklet. Family photographs would be a valuable addition. The AWM welcomes copies.

How the colourisation was done. An AI tool was used to suggest colours. Only those colours were then laid over the brightness of the original scan, so every feature of his face, every line and every shadow comes from the 1940 photograph itself. Nothing was redrawn or added.

> HIS FAMILY IN THE RECORDS
>
> **Mother:** Mildred Maud Phillips, of Lowaldie, his first next of kin. By September 1943 she was living at Borrika, where she wrote asking for the badge given to mothers of AIF volunteers.
>
> **Wife:** Irene May Phillips, married 25 March 1944. She became his next of kin (address Borrika) and was his widow in 1977, then living at Mile End.
>
> NAA: B883, SX8216, pp. 1–3, 5, 10, 20.

> PLACES IN HIS EARLY LIFE
>
> **Port Broughton**, on Spencer Gulf: his birthplace, 1917. **Lowaldie**, in the Murray Mallee east of Adelaide: his home and blacksmith's trade in 1940. **Borrika**, a neighbouring Mallee district: the family's address from 1943, and where his medals were sent in 1954.
>
> NAA: B883, SX8216, pp. 1, 2, 9, 10.

Enlistment, training and the voyage

From his own record

25 June 1940: medical examination in Adelaide, fit for Class I. He signs his attestation as a blacksmith of Lowaldie.

6 July: enlisted and sworn in at Adelaide as SX8216, graded Group I Blacksmith from that date.

9 July: reports to the Recruit Reception Depot. **16 July:** marched in to the **2/2nd Army Field Workshops**.

11–19 August: pre-embarkation leave. **14 September:** entrains for Melbourne. **15 September:** embarks for overseas. **12 October:** disembarks in the Middle East (Kantara, as read).

NAA: B883, SX8216, pp. 1–5, 10, 18.

The 2/2nd Army Field Workshops was raised in 1940 as a corps-level repair unit of the Australian Army Ordnance Corps. Brigadier Moran's history explains that its "Main Shop" (headquarters, general engineering, transport and instrument sections) and No. 4 Recovery Section were raised in Victoria, while **Nos. 5 and 6 Recovery Sections were raised in South Australia and trained at Woodside Camp** in the Adelaide Hills.

What his unit was doing

On 16 August 1940 the unit's officers visited Adelaide: "No. 5 & 6 Recovery Section were visited but no parades were held as most of the personnel was on pre-embarkation leave." Cyril's own leave (11–19 August) matches exactly.

Moran writes: "The two Recovery Sections from South Australia entrained for Melbourne, joined the rest of the Main Shop and 4 Recovery Section and embarked on the M.V. *Nieuw Holland* at Port Melbourne on 15 September. They called at Fremantle and Ceylon and reached Suez… They sailed up the Canal to Kantara, and by rail to Helwan."

AWM52 14/2/2/2; Moran, *The Story of the 2/2 Army Field Workshops* (1964), pp. 9, 12.

The evidence suggests: his ship was the *Nieuw Holland* — high · about 90%

His record does not name the ship, but the dates match the South Australian recovery sections exactly. He entrained in South Australia on 14 September, embarked at Melbourne on 15 September and landed on 12 October, the day after the convoy reached Suez. The Dutch liner *Nieuw Holland* sailed in convoy US 5, which left Fremantle on 22 September 1940.

Based on: NAA B883 SX8216 pp. 5, 10 (dates; his mother: "my son sailed on the 14th Sept 1940"). Moran pp. 12–13 (ship, route, arrival 11 Oct). AWM photo P01522.014: 2/2nd Field Workshop men "aboard the troop transport Nieuw Holland en route to the Middle East", 1940. Convoy US 5: Naval Historical Society of Australia.

The evidence suggests: he belonged to a South Australian recovery section — strong · about 80%

He joined the unit in South Australia on 16 July 1940, when the only parts of 2/2 AFW in the state were Nos. 5 and 6 Recovery Sections at Woodside. He then travelled with them. Which of the two is discussed in Chapter three. The weight of evidence points to **No. 6**.

Based on: NAA p. 5 (marched in to 2/2 AFW 16 Jul 1940 in 4 Military District). Moran p. 9 (sections and camps, Aug 1940). AWM52 14/2/2/2 (16 Aug 1940 entry).



Helwan, Egypt, late 1940. *Men of the 2/2nd Army Field Workshops with the "L" trailer, one of the unit's mobile machine shops. The unit's camp was here from October to December 1940. Photo Frank Hurley.* AWM 004227 · PUBLIC DOMAIN

Egypt and Libya: the first desert campaign

From Helwan, near Cairo, the 2/2nd Army Field Workshops moved into the Western Desert in December 1940 as corps troops, attached to the British XIII Corps, just as General O'Connor's offensive drove the Italian army out of Egypt. The unit's job was to keep the army moving. It recovered broken-down and captured vehicles, repaired trucks, guns and watches, and above all kept the few British "I" tanks fit to fight.

What his unit was doing

5 Dec 1940: Main Shop and No. 6 Recovery Section to Amiriya. **16 Dec:** to Fuka. **23–27 Dec:** 6 Recovery Section forms the advance party at "Kilo 104" on the coast near Sidi Barrani.

3–5 Jan 1941: Bardia falls. Main Shop and "all 6 Rec Sec" work at the 7th Royal Tank Regiment's lager. Captains Naismith and Redpath and their teams get 20 tanks fit for the next battle.

21–22 Jan: the capture of Tobruk. A detachment of 6 Recovery Section "went 'in' with the tanks, put five disabled ones into service again when under fire and won three military medals" (Sgt Allison, Ptes Smith and Dunning). **24 Jan:** Main Shop to Ain el Gazala.

Feb 1941: 6 Recovery Section pushes on via Giovanni Berta and Tecnis. The Main Shop works at Maddalena near Barce. **9–29 Mar:** 6 Recovery Section works at Mersa Matruh (432 jobs) and returns to Amiriya.

AWM52 14/2/2/2 to 14/2/2/5; Moran pp. 13–22, 36.

The evidence suggests: Christmas 1940 at Fuka

moderate

If Cyril was in 6 Recovery Section, he most likely spent Christmas 1940 at Fuka. Moran says the Main Shop worked there until 26 December and moved to Kilo 104 "accompanied by the flexible 6 Rec. Sec." the next day. The unit's seven-course Christmas dinner at Fuka, with "a free bottle of Abbotts lager beer each", was photographed. The diary has a 6 Recovery Section advance party at Kilo 104 from 23 December, so he may instead have been with that party.

Based on: Moran p. 13; AWM52 14/2/2/2 (16 and 23 Dec 1940); AWM photos P01522.001 and P01522.003.



Fuka, Egypt, December 1940. *The 2/2nd Field Workshop cookhouse decorated for Christmas, with the sign "Mongareya Tavern". Second from left is Captain John William Redpath, who commanded No. 6 Recovery Section. Donor J. Alexander.* AWM P01522.003 · PUBLIC DOMAIN



Maddalena, Cyrenaica, February 1941. *Looking down on the 2/2 Army Field Workshops camp after the fall of Benghazi. Photo Frank Hurley.* AWM 006532 · PUBLIC DOMAIN

From his own record

His record has no entries between his arrival in October 1940 and June 1941. That means no wounds, illness, transfers or offences, so he stayed with his unit throughout this campaign. His later medals include the **Africa Star**, which was awarded for service in North Africa.

NAA: B883, SX8216, pp. 5, 9.

Tobruk: the siege and "the windmill"

In March 1941 most of the 2/2nd Army Field Workshops went back to Egypt to prepare for the expedition to Greece. No. 5 Recovery Section went to Greece. On 5 April **No. 6 Recovery Section left Amiriya for Tobruk**, and it arrived before Rommel's Afrika Korps surrounded the fortress. For three months it was the only part of the unit inside the siege, keeping the defenders' vehicles and guns in action.

What his unit was doing

8 Apr 1941: 6 Recovery Section, under Captain J.W. Redpath, in Tobruk. **11 Apr:** "No. 6 Recovery Section moved out to position on Derna Road about 1 mile West of Tobruk." **22 Apr:** Redpath writes from Tobruk that the section has had no losses.

Moran: "The other absent member, '6 Recovery Section', was besieged in Tobruk. **Their site was at the windmill** and with craftsmen of the 2/1 Army Field Workshops and the LADs helped in the successful defence of the fortress."

7–11 Jul 1941: 6 Recovery Section leaves Tobruk. "Capt. Redpath and No. 6 Rec. Sec. marched in from Tobruk" to Barbara, Palestine, on 11 July.

AWM52 14/2/1/4 (2/1 AFW, 8 and 11 Apr 1941); AWM52 14/2/2/5, 14/2/2/6; Moran pp. 36, 41.

From his own record

14 June 1941: admitted to "4 Aust Gen Hosp" with influenza. **17 June:** discharged (enteritis) and **rejoined his unit the same day**.

NAA: B883, SX8216, p. 5.



Tobruk, 1941. *Looking across the Derna Road from Post S17, near the head of the Wadi Sehel, on the western side of the perimeter.* AWM 128987 · PUBLIC DOMAIN

The evidence suggests: he was in Tobruk during the siege

PROBABLE · ABOUT 70–75%

The 2/4th Australian General Hospital was **inside besieged Tobruk** from 26 March to 21 October 1941. In June 1941 Cyril was treated at "4 AGH" and was back with his unit on the day he was discharged. That is only possible if his unit was close by, and the only part of 2/2 AFW in Tobruk was No. 6 Recovery Section. He had not gone to Greece with No. 5 Section, because his record has no Greek service, and he appears on 6 Recovery Section guard rosters later in 1941.

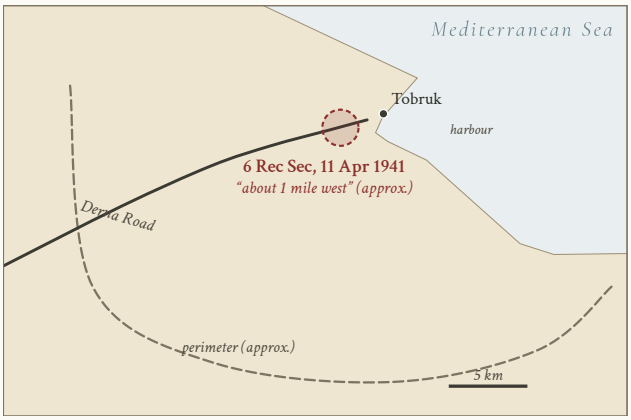
Based on: NAA p. 5 (14–17 Jun 1941). 2/4 AGH location: Our Contribution wiki. Moran pp. 36, 41. AWM52 14/2/2/7–8 (guard rosters, Chapter four). Caveat: his record never names his section, and twelve 6 Recovery Section men on leave could not get back into Tobruk in April 1941 (AWM52 14/2/2/5, 15 Apr). A 2/4 AGH admission register would settle it.

The evidence suggests: where "the windmill" was

MODERATE

Moran does not say where the windmill stood. The only fix on the section's position is the war diary's "Derna Road about 1 mile West of Tobruk" (11 April 1941). The windmill was most likely a wind-pump or well-head on or near the Derna Road, just west of the town and well inside the perimeter. No wartime map marking it has yet been found.

Based on: AWM52 14/2/1/4, 11 Apr 1941; Moran p. 41. To check: AWM Tobruk maps (LIB52519; the Italian 1:50,000 "Tobruch" sheet) and the 2/1 AFW diaries for May–June 1941.



Tobruk and the Derna Road (schematic). The shaded circle marks "about 1 mile west of Tobruk", the 11 April 1941 position of 6 Recovery Section. The windmill site is inferred, not plotted from a wartime map.

Palestine, Transjordan and Lebanon

After the Syrian campaign the reunited 2/2nd Army Field Workshops served the Allied armies in Palestine, Transjordan and Lebanon. In this period Cyril's name finally appears in his unit's own papers. The daily Routine Orders list him on the camp guard several times.

What his unit was doing

11 Jul 1941: 6 Recovery Section reaches Barbara, near Ascalon (Ashkelon), and goes on seven days' leave, then to an infantry training school. **Aug 1941:** the unit moves to Beit Jirja, then Khassa. **27 Aug–12 Sep:** 6 Recovery Section services the 5th Indian Division at pumping station H4, on the oil pipeline in Transjordan.

Oct 1941: the unit moves to the Ablah barracks in Lebanon, 3,000 feet up between the Lebanon and Anti-Lebanon ranges. **11–13 Nov:** 6 Recovery Section goes to Mafraq and H4 on road patrol for the Ninth Army. Winter brings snow, and more than 100 frozen and cracked engine blocks are welded. **27 Jan 1942:** the unit leaves Syria and reaches Port Said on 20 February.

AWM52 14/2/2/6–8; Moran pp. 42–46.



Ablah, Lebanon (then "Syria"), November 1941. *Men of the 2/2nd Army Field Workshops overhauling a veteran 25-pounder gun. Cyril's unit orders place him at Ablah that month.* AWM 021687 · PUBLIC DOMAIN

Named in unit orders

22 Sep 1941, Khassa: Routine Orders M/S No. 98. Duty section for 23 September: "6 Recovery Sec." The guard includes "**SX8216 Phillips, C.R.**", alongside 6 Recovery Section men such as K. Smith, MM.

29 Sep 1941, Khassa: Routine Orders No. 4. Duty section: "H.Q. & 6 Rec Secs". The guard includes Phillips, C.R. and Dunning, MM, of 6 Recovery Section.

29 Oct 1941, Ablah: Routine Orders No. 25, signed by Lt-Col Moran. Phillips C.R. is on the guard for 30 October (duty section: MT Section).

6 Nov 1941, Ablah: Routine Orders No. 32. Duty section: "H.Q. and 6 Aust Rec Sec". The guard includes SX8216 Phillips C.R.

AWM52 14/2/2/7 (Aug–Sep 1941) and 14/2/2/8 (Oct–Nov 1941).

The evidence suggests: No. 6 Recovery Section

STRONG · ABOUT 80%

Three of the four guards that name him were drawn from 6 Recovery Section, and on two of them he stands beside known members of that section, including two of its Military Medal winners. Together with his South Australian enlistment, his voyage and the Tobruk hospital entry, this makes 6 Recovery Section by far the most likely place for Cyril.

Based on: the four Routine Orders above. NAA pp. 5, 18. Moran pp. 9, 12, 41. **Against:** one guard (29 Oct) came from MT Section. When the unit was reorganised in September 1942, 5 and 6 Recovery Sections were kept "as complete as possible" in No. 2 Army Ordnance Workshop, but Cyril was posted to 6 Div Ordnance Workshop (AWM52 14/2/2/9).

From his own record

12 Mar 1942: embarks in the Middle East. **27 Mar 1942:** disembarks in Ceylon.

NAA: B883, SX8216, p. 5.

Ceylon, home, and a new army

With Japan now in the war, the 6th and 7th Divisions were recalled from the Middle East. Part of the 6th Division, including Cyril's unit, was landed in Ceylon to help defend the island against a feared Japanese attack.

WHAT HIS UNIT WAS DOING

The unit embarked at Suez in the transports *Westernland*, *Clan McTavish*, *Gogra* and *Cromarty*, sailed on 13 March 1942, called at Aden and reached Colombo on 27 March. The first big Japanese air raid on Colombo came soon after they arrived. The unit camp, at "Maddagedera" as Moran spells it, became an engineering centre for the force. Moran remembered "hard work, intense heat; followed by torrential rain".

Moran p. 47.

FROM HIS OWN RECORD

27 Mar 1942: disembarks in Ceylon. 7 **Aug 1942:** disembarks at Melbourne "ex HMT *Ekma*". The handwritten date could be read as 4 August, but the typed discharge summary and the unit diary both give 7 August.

13 Aug–6 Sep: leave. **15 Sep 1942:** transferred to **6 Aust Div Ordnance Workshop**. **3 Nov:** entrains for Queensland.

NAA: B883, SX8216, pp. 5, 6, 18; AWM52 14/2/2/9 ("the period 13.7.42 to 7.8.42 having been spent at sea").

WHAT HIS UNIT WAS DOING

After arriving at Melbourne, the unit camped at Mangalore, Victoria, marched through Melbourne with the 17th Brigade, and in September moved to Minimbah and Greta in the Hunter Valley, NSW. There it was broken up "as an Army Ordnance Workshop, and a Divisional Ordnance Workshop of H.Q. and two Bde Group Workshops". On 15 September, the day Cyril's transfer took effect, "No I Group 6 Div Wkshop moved from Minimbah to Greta".

AWM52 14/2/2/9, Aug–Sep 1942.

"No. 1 Group" and "No. 2 Group"

The 6 Div Ordnance Workshop was organised as a headquarters and **two brigade group workshops**. Each was a self-contained repair section meant to move with one of the division's infantry brigades. In the war diary these appear as "No. 1 Group" and "No. 2 Group". By mid-1943 Cyril's record calls his section the "**16 Bde Sec 6 Aust Div W/S**", the section supporting the 16th Infantry Brigade. These sections later became separately numbered brigade workshops. Moran mentions the 2/119 and 2/120 Brigade Workshops, and Cyril joined the 2/121st in July 1943.

Not to be confused with his trade grading, "Group I Blacksmith". That was a pay classification for skilled tradesmen (see "What the trade terms mean").

AWM52 14/2/2/9; NAA p. 6; Moran p. 47.

THE EVIDENCE SUGGESTS: HE WAS IN NO. 1 GROUP AT GRETA — MODERATE

His transfer date (15 September 1942) is the same day the diary records No. 1 Group of the 6 Div Workshop moving from Minimbah to Greta, and by 1943 he was in the 16 Bde Section. It is likely that "No. 1 Group" was the 16 Brigade group, but the diary seen so far does not say this in so many words.

BASED ON: NAA p. 6 (transfer 15 Sep 1942; "16 Bde Sec", 12 Jul 1943); AWM52 14/2/2/9 (15 Sep 1942).

FROM HIS OWN RECORD

8 Dec 1942: embarks at Townsville on the *Duntroon*. **12 Dec 1942:** disembarks in New Guinea.

NAA: B883, SX8216, pp. 6, 18.

New Guinea

Cyril reached New Guinea in December 1942, as the fighting at Buna, Gona and Sananda was coming to an end. He stayed for fourteen months. From December 1942 the army's ordnance workshops were transferred to the new Australian Electrical and Mechanical Engineers (AEME), and their privates became **craftsmen**. In September 1943 his mother addressed her letter to "Cfn C.R. Phillips, 2/121 Aust Bde Workshops A.E.M.E."

From his own record

12 Dec 1942: disembarks in New Guinea with the 16 Bde Section, 6 Aust Div Workshop.

12 Jul 1943: taken on strength by **2/121 Aust Bde Workshops** "from 16 Bde Sec 6 Aust Div W/S".

5–23 Sep 1943: to 128 Australian General Hospital (NYD, "not yet diagnosed"), then to the New Guinea Details Depot, then back to 2/121 Bde Workshops on 23 September.

29 Jan 1944: to 2/1 Australian General Hospital (then at Bootless Bay, about 20 km south-east of Port Moresby) for investigation. **1 Feb 1944:** re-graded from Group I Blacksmith to **Group I Fitter** (the specialty is written "Ins").

13 Feb 1944: carried aboard the 2/1st Australian Hospital Ship *Manunda* at **Port Moresby**.

NAA: B883, SX8216, pp. 2, 6, 10.



The 2/1st Hospital Ship *Manunda*, 1944. *Shown at Lae on 14 August 1944, carrying nursing staff of the 128th General Hospital, Port Moresby. Cyril went home aboard her from Port Moresby in February 1944.* AWM 075198 · PUBLIC DOMAIN

The evidence suggests: the Port Moresby area — HIGH · ABOUT 85%

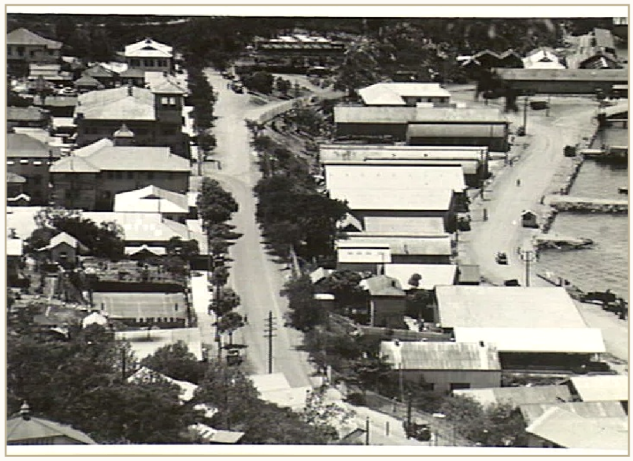
Everything that can be placed points to Port Moresby. He sailed from Townsville on the *Duntroon*, the usual run to Moresby. Both hospitals he was admitted to were in the Port Moresby area: 128 AGH at Port Moresby, and 2/1 AGH at Bootless Bay. In July–August 1943 the 2/121 Brigade Ordnance Field Park at Port Moresby lists "2/121 Aust Bde W/shops" among the units it serviced. He was evacuated from Port Moresby in 1944.

Based on: NAA pp. 6, 18 (Townsville–*Duntroon*–NG; 128 AGH; 2/1 AGH; *Manunda* at Port Moresby). AWM52 13/40/13/1 (2/121 Bde OFP, Jul–Aug 1943). AWM 075198 caption ("128th General Hospital, Port Moresby"). 2/1 AGH at Bootless Bay, Sep 1943–Jun 1944 (Our Contribution wiki; VWMA). Caveat: the war diaries of 16 Bde Section and 2/121 Bde Workshops were not found online, so detachments elsewhere (for example Wau or Milne Bay) cannot be ruled out.

The evidence suggests: what the 2/121st supported — MODERATE

The 2/121 Brigade Ordnance Field Park had previously been the "17 Bde Section, 6 Div OFP". That suggests the 2/121st Brigade units, Cyril's workshop included, were tied to the 6th Division's 17th Brigade, which fought at Wau and Salamaua in 1943.

Based on: AWM52 13/40/13/1 (title and opening entries). Not confirmed for the workshop itself.



Port Moresby, 29 December 1943. *Looking up Port Road, the town's main street, towards the naval workshops, with Stanley Esplanade along the waterfront.* AWM 062135 · PUBLIC DOMAIN

Home, discharge and later life

From his own record

17–22 Feb 1944: lands at Brisbane, travels on No. 2 Australian Ambulance Train to 115 AGH (Heidelberg, Victoria), where essential hypertension is diagnosed (19 Feb), and then goes to 121 AGH (22 Feb), which had moved to Northfield, South Australia.

8–10 Mar: medical board, Class B. Discharged to the SA Lines of Communication Area Details Depot.

25 Mar 1944: marries Irene May. She becomes his next of kin.

26 Apr–26 May: attached to SA L of C Area Workshops AEME. **6–21 Jun:** to Queensland, posted to 7 **Technical Maintenance Section, attached Advanced LHQ Signals**. **24 Jun–3 Jul:** Linemen Mechanics Course No. 70 at 1 ATTD.

21 Aug: medical class Temporary D. **25 Sep:** back in Adelaide "for discharge". **2–18 Oct:** 105 Australian Military Hospital (hypertension, mild). Final board Class D on 17 October.

28 Nov 1944: discharged at Wayville, medically unfit. Total service 1,607 days: 1,129 overseas (691 in the Middle East and Ceylon, 437 in New Guinea).

NAA: B883, SX8216, pp. 1, 5–8, 14, 17, 18, 21.

His last papers call him "Sig Phillips", a reflection of his final posting with a signals headquarters. The Office of Australian War Graves recorded him in 1977 as a Craftsman, Corps of Electrical and Mechanical Engineers.

> *"This is a story of engineers and tradesmen… It tells of Australian civilians who were trained as soldiers and then applied their technical skills in war."*
>
> Brigadier George Moran, Preface to *The Story of the 2/2 Army Field Workshops* (1964)

His medals

From his own record

His medal card is ticked for six awards: the **1939–45 Star**, **Africa Star**, **Pacific Star**, **Defence Medal**, **War Medal 1939–45** and **Australia Service Medal 1939–45**. They were applied for in March 1954 and posted on 8 April 1954 (as read) to his Borrika address.

NAA: B883, SX8216, p. 9.

Worth knowing — for the family

The six ticks match what his service would be expected to earn: the 1939–45 Star and Africa Star for the Middle East, the Pacific Star for New Guinea, and the Defence Medal, War Medal and Australia Service Medal for his service overall. If, as seems probable, he served in the Tobruk siege, he would also have qualified as a "Rat of Tobruk". That was an association, not a medal. A next of kin can ask Defence Honours and Awards to confirm his entitlement. Replica sets can be bought privately for family display.

Based on: NAA p. 9 (medal card). The Tobruk inference in Chapter three.

Later life

From the records

Cyril died on 7 **January 1977**, aged 59. He was buried at **Dudley Park** on 11 January 1977. His widow, Mrs I.M. Phillips, was then living at Mile End, Adelaide. The Repatriation Department's file reference for him was MX 5497.

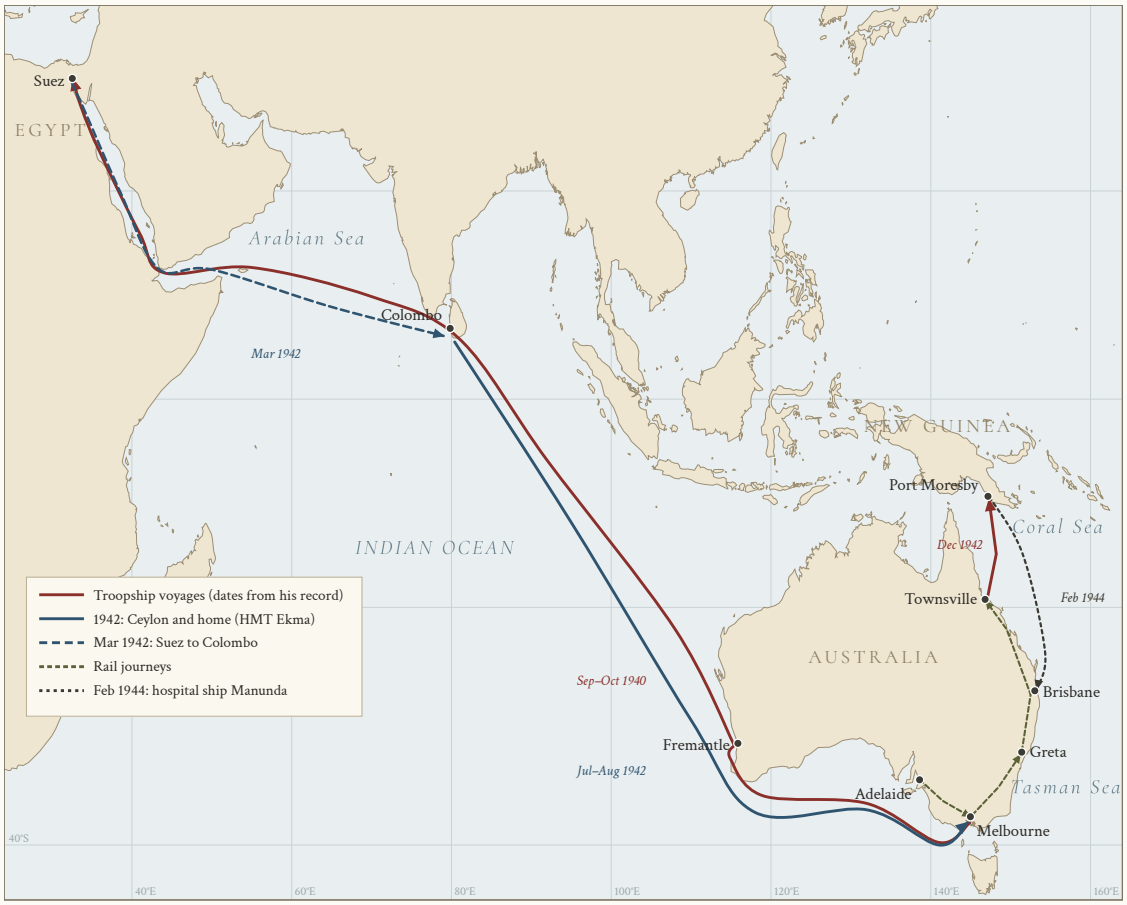
NAA: B883, SX8216, pp. 19–20 (DVA notice, 20 Jan 1977; Office of Australian War Graves card).

A lead for the family — unverified

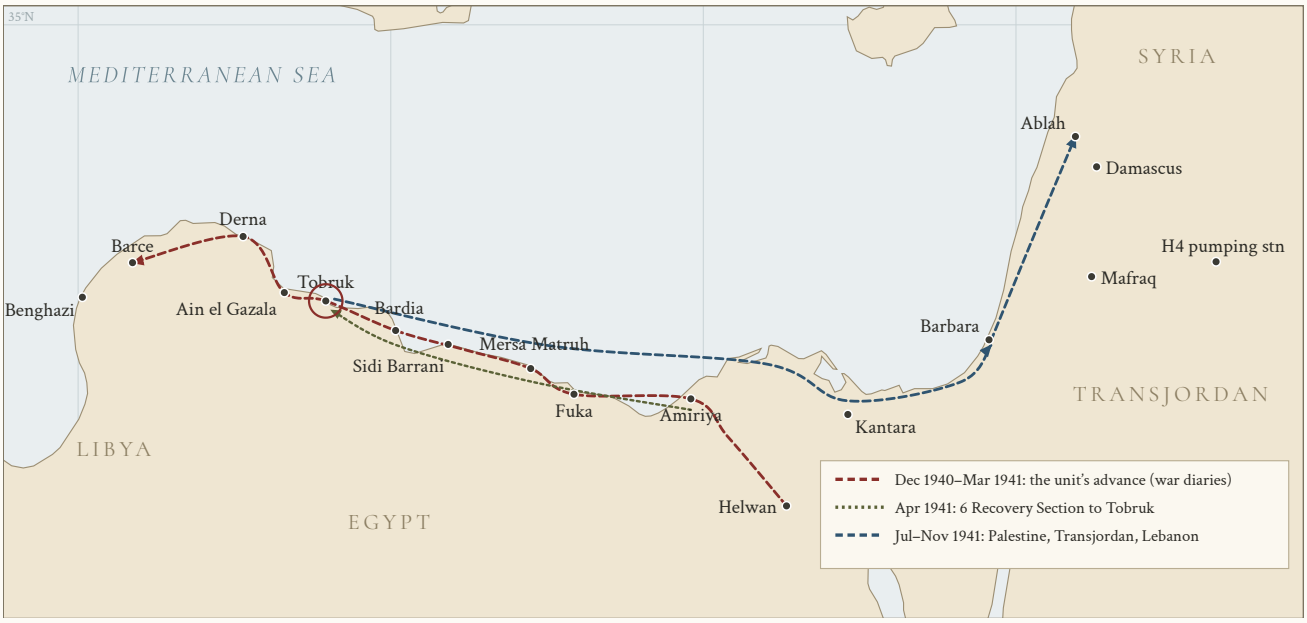
A published family tree (Colin Sandercock's tree) lists "Dohnt, Irene May & Cyril Roy Phillips", which suggests Irene's maiden name was Dohnt. This has not been checked against a marriage certificate.

Based on: family.sandercock.net (Dohnt surname list). To confirm, order the 1944 marriage record from SA Births, Deaths and Marriages, or search *The Advertiser* on Trove for March 1944 and January 1977 family notices.

Where he went



The long voyages, 1940–1944. Dates and ports of embarkation and landing are from his service record. The 1940 route via Fremantle and Colombo follows Moran's account. The tracks between ports are drawn indicatively.



The Middle East, 1940–1942. These routes follow the 2/2nd Army Field Workshops and No. 6 Recovery Section as recorded in the war diaries. His own record confirms only his arrival (Kantara, Oct 1940), the June 1941 hospital stay and his departure (Mar 1942). The Tobruk circle is shown in detail in Chapter three.

TIMELINE

Service at a glance, 1940–1944

RECORD his own service record NAMED a unit document naming him UNIT what his unit or section was doing INFERENCE the evidence suggests

DATE	EVENT	BASIS	SOURCE
Enlistment and voyage · 1940			
25 Jun 1940	Medical examination, Adelaide: fit Class I. Signs attestation (blacksmith, Lowaldie).	RECORD	NAA pp. 1, 4
6 Jul 1940	Enlists as SX8216, Private, 2nd AIF. Graded Group I Blacksmith.	RECORD	NAA pp. 1, 5
16 Jul 1940	Marches in to 2/2 Army Field Workshops in South Australia.	RECORD	NAA p. 5
Jul–Sep 1940	Probably trains with the SA recovery sections at Woodside Camp.	INFERENCE	Moran p. 9
11–19 Aug 1940	Pre-embarkation leave.	RECORD	NAA p. 5
14–15 Sep 1940	Entrains for Melbourne. Embarks for overseas, very probably on MV *Nieuw Holland* (convoy US 5).	RECORD SHIP	NAA pp. 5, 10; Moran p. 12
12 Oct 1940	Disembarks in the Middle East (Kantara), then Helwan camp.	RECORD	NAA p. 5; AWM52 14/2/2/2
Egypt and Libya · 1940–41			
Dec 1940	Unit to Amiriya and Fuka. 6 Rec Sec advance party at Kilo 104 near Sidi Barrani. Christmas dinner at Fuka.	UNIT	AWM52 14/2/2/2; Moran p. 13
Jan 1941	Bardia (3–5 Jan) and Tobruk (21–22 Jan) captured. 6 Rec Sec men win three MMs at Tobruk.	UNIT	AWM52 14/2/2/3; Moran p. 22
Feb–Mar 1941	Barce and Maddalena. 6 Rec Sec at Mersa Matruh, back to Amiriya 29 Mar.	UNIT	AWM52 14/2/2/5
5–11 Apr 1941	6 Rec Sec leaves Amiriya for Tobruk, arrives before the siege, and moves to the Derna Road about 1 mile west of the town ("the windmill").	UNIT HE	Moran pp. 36, 41; AWM52 14/2/1/4
14–17 Jun 1941	In 4 AGH (influenza, then enteritis) and rejoins his unit the same day. The 2/4 AGH was in Tobruk.	RECORD TOBRUK	NAA p. 5
7–11 Jul 1941	6 Rec Sec leaves Tobruk and marches in to Barbara, Palestine.	UNIT	AWM52 14/2/2/6
Palestine, Transjordan and Lebanon · 1941–42			
Aug–Sep 1941	Beit Jirja and Khassa. 6 Rec Sec at pumping station H4, Transjordan.	UNIT	AWM52 14/2/2/7
22 & 29 Sep 1941	On the guard at Khassa with 6 Rec Sec ("SX8216 Phillips, C.R.").	NAMED	AWM52 14/2/2/7
29 Oct & 6 Nov 1941	On the guard at Ablah barracks, Lebanon (6 Nov: HQ and 6 Rec Sec).	NAMED	AWM52 14/2/2/8
Nov 1941–Jan 1942	6 Rec Sec at Mafraq and H4. Winter at Ablah. The unit leaves Syria on 27 Jan.	UNIT	AWM52 14/2/2/8; Moran p. 46

Date	Event	Basis	Source
Ceylon and home · 1942			
12–27 Mar 1942	Embarks in the Middle East and lands in Ceylon. Unit camp at "Maddagedera".	Record	NAA p. 5; Moran p. 47
13 Jul–7 Aug 1942	At sea on HMT *Ekma*. Lands at Melbourne on 7 Aug; unit to Mangalore, Vic.	Record	NAA pp. 5, 18; AWM52 14/2/2/9
13 Aug–6 Sep 1942	Leave.	Record	NAA p. 6
15 Sep 1942	Transferred to 6 Aust Div Ordnance Workshop, Greta NSW. No. 1 Group moves from Minimbah to Greta that day.	Record Unit	NAA p. 6; AWM52 14/2/2/9
3 Nov 1942	Entrains for Queensland.	Record	NAA p. 6
New Guinea · 1942–44			
8–12 Dec 1942	Embarks at Townsville on *Duntroon* and lands in New Guinea, almost certainly at Port Moresby.	Record Port	NAA pp. 6, 18
12 Jul 1943	To 2/121 Aust Bde Workshops from 16 Bde Section, 6 Aust Div Workshop.	Record	NAA p. 6
Jul–Aug 1943	2/121 Bde Workshops serviced by 2/121 Bde OFP at Port Moresby.	Unit	AWM52 13/40/13/1
5–23 Sep 1943	In 128 AGH, Port Moresby (NYD), then the NG Details Depot, then back to his unit.	Record	NAA p. 6
6 Sep 1943	His mother writes from Borrika asking for her Mother's Badge: "Cfn C.R. Phillips, 2/121 Aust Bde Workshops AEME".	Record	NAA p. 10
29 Jan 1944	To 2/1 AGH (Bootless Bay) for investigation.	Record	NAA p. 6
1 Feb 1944	Re-graded Group I Fitter.	Record	NAA pp. 5, 6
13 Feb 1944	Embarks on Hospital Ship *Manunda* at Port Moresby.	Record	NAA p. 6
Home and discharge · 1944			
17–22 Feb 1944	Brisbane, then the ambulance train, then 115 AGH, Victoria (essential hypertension), then 121 AGH, Northfield SA.	Record	NAA pp. 6, 18
8–10 Mar 1944	Medical board, Class B. To SA L of C Area Details Depot.	Record	NAA pp. 6, 7
25 Mar 1944	Marries Irene May.	Record	NAA pp. 1, 5
26 Apr–26 May 1944	Attached to SA L of C Area Workshops AEME.	Record	NAA p. 7
Jun–Sep 1944	Queensland: 7 Tech Maint Section, attached Adv LHQ Signals. Linemen Mechanics Course No. 70.	Record	NAA p. 7
2–18 Oct 1944	105 AMH, Adelaide. Final board, Class D (17 Oct).	Record	NAA pp. 8, 14
28 Nov 1944	Discharged at Wayville, medically unfit. 1,607 days' service.	Record	NAA pp. 8, 18, 21
After the war			
Apr 1954	Six medals posted to him at Borrika.	Record	NAA p. 9
7 Jan 1977	Dies, aged 59. Buried at Dudley Park on 11 Jan 1977.	Record	NAA pp. 19, 20

NAA page numbers refer to the 21-page digitised copy of B883, SX8216 (item barcode 6411180). AWM52 numbers are the unit war diaries held by the Australian War Memorial. "Moran" is Brig. G.H.S. Moran, *The Story of the 2/2 Army Field Workshops* (Melbourne, 1964), cited by its printed page numbers.

What the trade terms mean

Army Field Workshops (AFW)
A large mobile repair unit serving a whole army corps. The 2/2nd had a "Main Shop" with machine-tool trailers, general engineering, motor transport, instrument and radio sections, and three Recovery Sections (Nos. 4, 5 and 6).

Group I tradesman
Skilled tradesmen were classed into numbered trade groups that set their extra "tradesman's pay". Group I was the top grade, for the most highly skilled trades. Cyril was a *Group I Blacksmith* from enlistment and a *Group I Fitter* from February 1944.

Craftsman (Cfn)
The rank used in the Australian Electrical and Mechanical Engineers instead of Private. Cyril is "Cfn" from 1943 and "Craftsman" on his 1977 war-graves card.

Ordnance Workshop / Brigade Workshops
After the 1942 reorganisation the big field workshops were broken into smaller units better suited to jungle war: a divisional workshop made up of brigade "groups" or sections, later numbered brigade workshops such as the 2/121st.

LAD (Light Aid Detachment)
A small repair team permanently attached to a regiment or battalion. Recovery Sections and LADs worked side by side, including in Tobruk.

AGH / AMH
Australian General Hospital / Australian Military Hospital. "2/4" means the 4th AGH of the Second AIF; Cyril's record writes it simply as "4 AGH".

NYD
"Not yet diagnosed". It was written on an admission before the doctors had decided what was wrong.

L of C Area
Lines of Communication Area: the state-based administrative commands that handled depots, hospitals and men in transit.

Recovery Section
The unit's most mobile element. It retrieved broken-down, bogged, damaged or captured vehicles, tanks and guns, often close to the fighting, and repaired what it could on the spot. No. 6 Recovery Section was raised in South Australia.

Blacksmith / Fitter
In a field workshop the blacksmiths forged and welded: springs, axles, recovery gear and cutting with oxy-acetylene. Fitters machined and assembled mechanical parts. "Ins" after Fitter is not spelled out in his file. It may stand for *instrument*.

AAOC → AEME → RAEME
The workshops began in the Australian Army Ordnance Corps. On 1 December 1942 they were transferred to the new Australian Electrical and Mechanical Engineers, which became the Royal Australian Electrical and Mechanical Engineers (RAEME) in 1948.

"No. 1 Group" / "No. 2 Group"
The two brigade group workshops of the 6 Div Ordnance Workshop formed at Greta in September 1942. These are workshop sub-units, not trade grades.

OFP (Ordnance Field Park)
The mobile store of spare parts and replacement equipment that supplied the workshops.

"X" list
Men temporarily away from their unit, usually in hospital, were moved to the "X" list and struck off it when they returned.

Medical classes A–D
Fitness gradings. Class B meant fit for limited duties and Class D meant unfit for service, which led to his discharge.

HMT
His Majesty's Transport, a requisitioned troopship.

SOURCES AND FURTHER RESEARCH

Where this comes from, and where to look next

His own records

- **NAA: B883, SX8216**, Phillips, Cyril Roy. Service record, 21 pages, digitised and open. Item barcode 6411180. recordsearch.naa.gov.au
- **WW2 Nominal Roll**, Phillips, Cyril Roy. Department of Veterans' Affairs. nominal-rolls.dva.gov.au

Unit war diaries (AWM52, Australian War Memorial)

- 14/2/2/2 to 14/2/2/9: 2/2 Army Field Workshops, May 1940 – Sep 1942 (C2908203–C2908210), including the Routine Orders that name him (14/2/2/7, 14/2/2/8).
- 14/2/1/4: 2/1 Army Field Workshops, Mar–Apr 1941 (6 Rec Sec on the Derna Road). C2908153
- 13/40/13/1: 2/121 Aust Bde Ordnance Field Park, Jul 1943 – May 1944. C2901636

Books and other sources

- Brig. G.H.S. Moran, *The Story of the 2/2 Army Field Workshops*, Melbourne, Outlook Press, 1964 (AWM LIB11198). A copy is online at the Rats of Tobruk tribute site: ratsoftobruktribute.com
- Naval Historical Society of Australia, "22 September 1940" (convoy US 5).
- Our Contribution wiki (birtwistlewiki.com.au): 2/4th, 2/1st and 121st Australian General Hospitals.

Photographs used (all AWM, copyright expired, public domain)

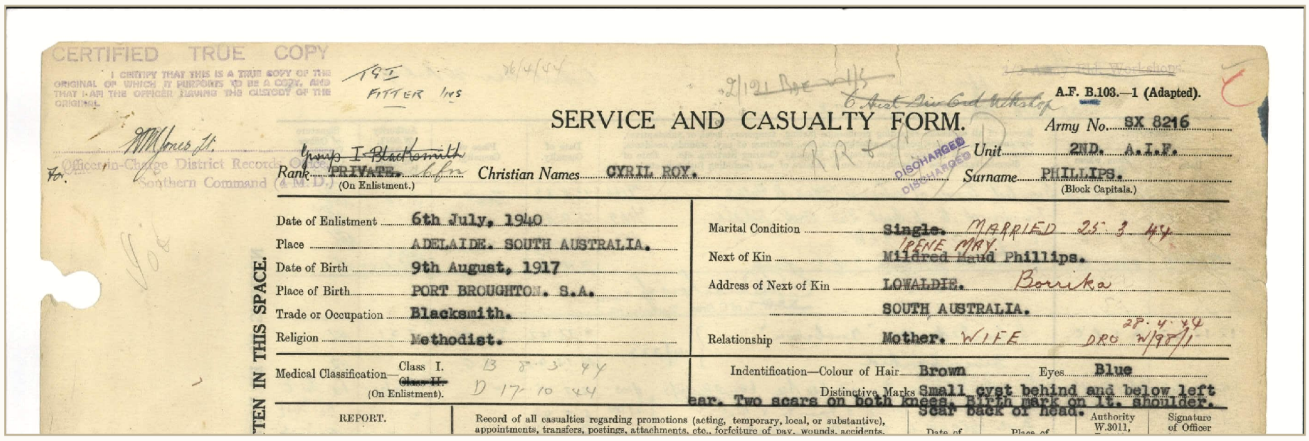
- 004227 Helwan, L trailer, 2/2 AFW · P01522.003 Fuka, Christmas 1940 · 006532 Maddalena camp · 128987 Derna Road, Tobruk · 021687 Ablah, 25-pounder · 075198 HS *Manunda* · 062135 Port Moresby, Dec 1943. Search any number at awm.gov.au.
- Portrait: NAA: B883, SX8216, p. 4 (attestation photograph).

Open questions, and how to answer them

- **Was he in 6 Recovery Section?** A 2/2 AFW nominal or embarkation roll would settle it. The NAA holds embarkation rolls, and the AWM Research Centre may hold the unit association's roll. The 2/2 Army Field Workshops Association papers are another possibility.
- **Was he in Tobruk?** The 2/4th AGH admission and discharge registers for June 1941 would show where he was admitted. Ask the NAA or the AWM Research Centre which of them holds the registers.
- **Where was "the windmill"?** Check AWM maps of Tobruk (for example LIB52519 and the Italian 1:50,000 "Tobruch" sheet) for a wind-pump or well about a mile west of the town on the Derna Road. The 2/1 AFW diaries for May–June 1941 may also mention it.
- **May–June 1941 diary.** The 2/2 AFW diary for these months is missing from the AWM's digitised series. Ask the AWM whether it survives.
- **New Guinea detail.** The war diaries of 6 Div Ordnance Workshop (16 Bde Section), Dec 1942 – Jul 1943, and of 2/121 Bde Workshops, 1943–44, were not found online. Ask the AWM Research Centre.
- **His medical and repatriation file.** His DVA file MX 5497 (NAA, South Australian repatriation series) may describe his illness and later life.
- **Family notices.** Search *The Advertiser* on Trove for his March 1944 wedding and January 1977 death notices. Dudley Park Cemetery's burial register will give the exact grave location.
- **Photographs.** If the family holds wartime photographs or letters, the AWM and the State Library of South Australia welcome copies.

A note on accuracy. Every date in this booklet was checked against the original page images of his service record and the war diaries. Where a handwritten entry is hard to read, the reading is marked "as read". Where his own record is silent, the booklet says so, and inferences are always labelled with their reasoning. Corrections from family memory or papers are very welcome.

From the original record



CERTIFIED TRUE COPY

SERVICE AND CASUALTY FORM. A.F. B.103.—1 (Adapted).

Army No. SX 8216

Rank PRIVATE. (On Enlistment.) Christian Names CYRIL ROY. Surname PHILLIPS. (Block Capitals.)

Unit 2ND. A.I.F.

DISCHARGED

Date of Enlistment 6th July, 1940

Place ADELAIDE. SOUTH AUSTRALIA.

Date of Birth 9th August, 1917

Place of Birth PORT BROUGHTON. S.A.

Trade or Occupation Blacksmith.

Religion Methodist.

Marital Condition Single. MARRIED 25.3.44

Next of Kin Mildred Maud Phillips. IRENE MAY

Address of Next of Kin LOWALDIE. Borrika SOUTH AUSTRALIA.

Relationship Mother. WIFE

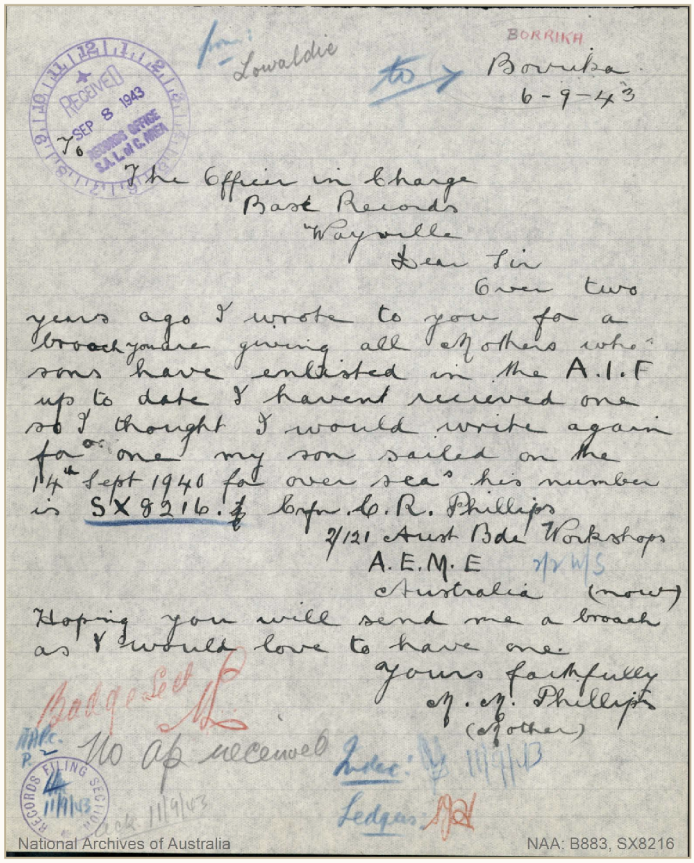
Medical Classification Class I. (On Enlistment.)

Identification—Colour of Hair Brown Eyes Blue

Distinctive Marks Small cyst behind and below left ear. Two scars on both knees. Birth mark on lt. shoulder. Scar back of head.

REPORT. Record of all casualties regarding promotions (acting, temporary, local, or substantive), appointments, transfers, postings, attachments, etc., forfeiture of pay, wounds, accidents.

Service and Casualty Form (A.F. B.103), top section. *Shows his enlistment, birth at Port Broughton, trade, and next of kin, first his mother Mildred Maud Phillips of Lowaldie, amended to his wife Irene May after 25.3.44. Note "Brown" hair and "Blue" eyes. NAA: B883, SX8216, p. 5.*



From Lowaldie to Borrika 6-9-43

RECEIVED 7 SEP 8 1943

The Officer in Charge
Base Records
Wayville

Dear Sir

Over two years ago I wrote to you for a broach you are giving all Mothers who's sons have enlisted in the A.I.F up to date I havent received one so I thought I would write again for one my son sailed on the 14th Sept 1940 for over seas his number is SX8216. his name is C.R. Phillips 2/12 Aust Bde Workshops A.E.M.E Australia (now)

Hoping you will send me a broach as I would love to have one.

Yours faithfully
M. M. Phillips
(Mother)

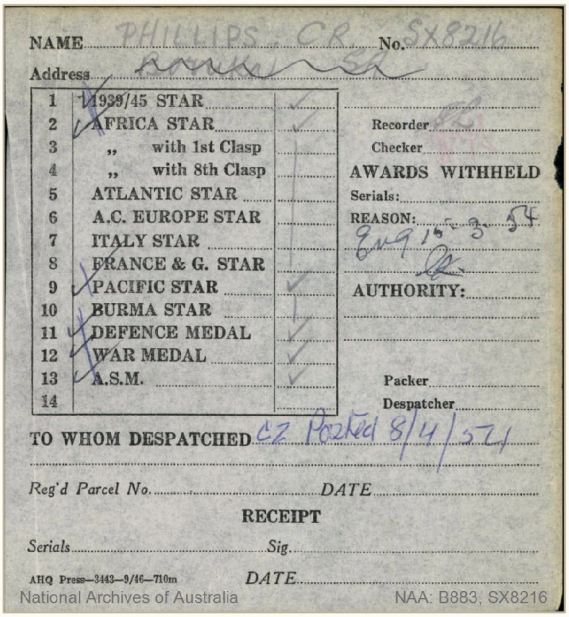
Badge Sect

No as received

Ledger

National Archives of Australia NAA: B883, SX8216

His mother's letter, Borrika, 6 September 1943. *"Over two years ago I wrote to you for a broach you are giving all Mothers whose sons have enlisted in the A.I.F. ... my son sailed on the 14th Sept 1940 for over seas his number is SX8216 ... Hoping you will send me a broach as I would love to have one." The note "Badge Sect" shows it was passed on for action. NAA: B883, SX8216, p. 10.*



NAME PHILLIPS C.R. No. SX8216

Address

1	1939/45 STAR	✓
2	AFRICA STAR	✓
3	,, with 1st Clasp	
4	,, with 8th Clasp	
5	ATLANTIC STAR	
6	A.C. EUROPE STAR	
7	ITALY STAR	
8	FRANCE & G. STAR	
9	PACIFIC STAR	✓
10	BURMA STAR	
11	DEFENCE MEDAL	✓
12	WAR MEDAL	✓
13	A.S.M.	✓
14		

Recorder
Checker
AWARDS WITHHELD
Serials:
REASON: 15.3.54
AUTHORITY:
Packer
Despatcher

TO WHOM DESPATCHED CZ Posted 8/4/54

Reg'd Parcel No. DATE

RECEIPT

Serials Sig.

AHQ Press—3443—9/46—710m DATE

National Archives of Australia NAA: B883, SX8216

His medal card. *Ticked for the 1939/45 Star, Africa Star, Pacific Star, Defence Medal, War Medal and A.S.M. It notes an enquiry of 15-3-54 and "Posted 8/4/54" (as read). NAA: B883, SX8216, p. 9.*